## READING PASSAGE 3

*You should spend about 20 minutes on **Questions 27-40**, which are based on Reading Passage 3 below.*

# The origin of language

*The archaeologist Stephen Mithen talks about the ideas behind his new book on the origin of language.*

Theories on the origin and evolution of language have been a major area of my research for many years. By 1859, when British scientist Charles Darwin published *The Origin of Species*, there was already a great deal of interest in this subject. However, the debate became plagued by strange theories, so much so that in 1866 the influential Société de Linguistique de Paris banned all discussions about the origin of language. The ban lasted for more than a century, before a surge of research began during the 1990s. Linguists, psychologists, anthropologists and archaeologists now frequently debate the origin of language and have published many articles and books on this topic. And yet, despite almost frenzied activity, limited progress has been made.

I believe there are four reasons for this. The first is an insufficient concern with the archaeological and fossil proof of the brains and behaviour of our human ancestors. Many theories to date rely on an assumed association between brain size and language abilities, without acknowledging the problem this creates: fossil evidence indicates that the Neanderthals had larger brains than modern humans, *Homo sapiens*, but archaeological evidence indicates that the Neanderthals lacked a capacity for language. So something is seriously amiss with those theories.

That 'something' might relate to the second reason for limited progress: insufficient concern with the other major aural and vocal communication system of modern humans: music. Even though the Société de Linguistique de Paris had nothing to say about studying the origin of music, academics appear to have had a self-imposed ban, with limited discussion of this issue during the 19th and 20th centuries. However, there are notable exceptions that should be acknowledged. One is the aforementioned Charles Darwin who, in his 1871 book on human evolution, *The Descent of Man*, devoted several pages to the development of music. Another is the renowned ethnomusicologist John Blacking, whose 1973 book, *How Musical is Man?*, broached the idea that music is an inherent and universal human quality.

The origin of music deserves as much attention as that of language, as we cannot treat one without the other. Those writers who had evidently annoyed the Société de Linguistique de Paris were quite aware of this. For them, music and language were intimately linked; the French writer and philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau's *On the Origin of Language* (1781) was a reflection on both music and language. In contrast, Morten Christiansen and Simon Kirby's book, *Language Evolution* (2000), which they conceived as 'a definitive book on the

subject', failed to mention music in any of its 17 chapters. Those authors have an important lesson to learn from Rousseau and other writers of his time who addressed the origin of language.

Music is a universal feature of human society and plays a significant role in the lives of all individuals. Indeed, music is perhaps in even greater need of study than language: the latter has a self-evident function—the transmission of information—and can be readily accepted as a product of evolution, even if its specific evolutionary history remains unclear. But what is the point of music?

That question leads directly to a third reason for our lack of progress in understanding how language evolved, and indeed the human mind in general: an insufficient concern with emotion. If music is about anything, it is about expressing emotion. But while archaeologists have put significant effort into examining the intellectual capacities of our ancestors, their emotional lives have been sorely neglected. This has contributed to the neglect of music, which, in turn, has constrained our understanding of language.

There is one further reason why progress has been limited: those who have been most influential regarding the evolution of language have simply got it wrong, and misled everyone else. Linguist Derek Bickerton has made an important contribution towards our understanding of the origin of language by bringing his profound knowledge of linguistics to the discussions that have occurred. But Bickerton's idea that the precursor of modern language consisted of words strung together with limited, if any, grammar is, I believe, fundamentally mistaken. Bickerton refers to this precursor as 'proto-language' and suggests that it was similar to the type of language spoken by young children today, and mastered by apes through the use of computer keyboards. This idea has dominated the field of language origins for the last two decades, and is one that I once found persuasive. But I now understand that it is not only flawed but has severely limited the progress that should have been made.

My book therefore provides an alternative view, one that draws on the ideas of a linguist who has, I believe, identified the true nature of proto-language. Her name is Alison Wray. She argues that proto-language was 'holistic' rather than compositional in character. By this she means that the precursor to language was a communication system composed of 'messages' rather than words; each message was uniquely associated with an arbitrary meaning, as are the utterances of language today. But in Wray's proto-language, they were not composed out of smaller units of meaning (i.e. words) which could be combined together using a rule system (i.e. grammar) to make more complex messages with emergent meanings. For Wray, proto-language was semantically complex and agrammatical. I believe this insight enables us to understand the origin of music as well as language, and to relate both to the emotional lives of our human ancestors.

*Questions 27–31*

*Choose the correct letter,* ***A, B, C*** *or* ***D****.*

*Write the correct letter in boxes 27–31 on your answer sheet.*

**27** In the first paragraph, what does the writer suggest about the origin of language?

**A** Too many branches of science have been involved in its study.
**B** The Société de Linguistique de Paris instigated research in this area.
**C** The lack of progress is surprising given the amount of work being done.
**D** Most progress in the study of language was made between 1859 and 1866.

**28** What is the 'problem' referred to in the second paragraph?

**A** Some current theories are based on conflicting evidence.
**B** There is insufficient fossil evidence to reach a conclusion.
**C** Fossil evidence suggests that Homo sapiens had larger brains than Neanderthals.
**D** Archaeological evidence shows that Neanderthals were able to talk.

**29** What does the writer suggest about Jean-Jacques Rousseau's work in 1781?

**A** Modern theorists should pay more attention to his approach.
**B** His ideas supported those of the Société de Linguistique de Paris.
**C** His ideas were mirrored in a later book called *Language Evolution*.
**D** His ideas are too outdated to be of any relevance today.

**30** What is the writer's current view of Derek Bickerton's ideas?

**A** They have had little impact on the study of language.
**B** They have helped the study of linguistics to progress.
**C** They are not accepted by the majority of linguists.
**D** The assumption behind them is wrong.

**31** In the final paragraph, the writer concludes that Alison Wray's ideas will help establish a link between

**A** grammar and meaning.
**B** messages and proto-language.
**C** language, music and emotions.
**D** proto-language and modern semantics.

*Questions 32–37*

*Complete each sentence with the correct ending,* ***A–H****, below.*

*Write the correct letter,* ***A–H****, in boxes 32–37 on your answer sheet.*

**32** The Société de Linguistique de Paris

**33** Charles Darwin

**34** John Blacking

**35** Christiansen and Kirby

**36** Derek Bickerton

**37** Alison Wray

**A** suggested music was an essential part of every individual.
**B** made no link between music and language in a comprehensive study.
**C** believes that early language was very musical.
**D** felt that the origin of language should not be debated.
**E** states that early language was made up of basic words used in an unsystematic way.
**F** devoted 17 chapters of a book to music.
**G** believes that proto-language had no individual words.
**H** referred to music in part of a book about the development of human beings.

*Questions 38–40*

*Choose **THREE** letters, **A–G**.*

*Write the correct letters in boxes 38–40 on your answer sheet.*

According to the writer, which **THREE** of the following areas have not been studied enough in order to understand the origin of language?

**A** evidence from prehistoric times
**B** intelligence
**C** individual sounds
**D** music
**E** emotions
**F** human intellect
**G** children's language

**Disclaimer**
Compiled, formatted, and lightly proofread by ZYZ Reading Walks.
All copyright in the underlying works remains with the original authors and publishers.
No affiliation with or endorsement by any rights holder (including IELTS® owners).
For non-commercial educational use only. This notice must remain intact in all copies.
Available free of charge from ZYZ Reading Walks. Resale or any paid distribution is prohibited.

## 题型一：单选题 27–31

| 题号 | 答案 | 题干翻译 | 详细定位（第 X 段 原句） | 定位句翻译 | 详细解析（含排除） |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 27 | C | 在第一段中，作者对语言起源研究有什么暗示？ | **第 1 段**：“*And yet, despite almost frenzied activity, limited progress has been made.*” | “然而，尽管研究活动几乎到了狂热的程度，进展却十分有限。” | **选 C**：“工作量很大但进展很少，这种缺乏进展（在如此多研究之下）很值得注意/令人意外。”题干问 *suggest*（暗示），作者用 “despite… limited progress” 表达 “做很多但进展少” 的反差。**排除 A：**文中没说 “学科太多导致问题”，只是列举现在有多学科在讨论，并非批评 “太多”。**排除 B：第 1 段说该协会在 1866 年禁止讨论，完全不是 “促进研究”。**排除 D：**1859–1866 之间并未说 “进展最大”，反而说后来长期禁令，整体 “进展有限”。 |
| 28 | A | 第二段中提到的 “problem（问题）” 是什么？ | **第 2 段**：“*…an assumed association between brain size and language abilities… fossil evidence indicates that the Neanderthals had larger brains than modern humans… but archaeological evidence indicates that the Neanderthals lacked a capacity for language.*” | “许多理论假设大脑大小与语言能力相关；但化石证据显示尼安德特人脑更大，而考古证据却显示他们缺乏语言能力。” | **选 A**：“一些当代理论建立在互相冲突的证据之上。”这里的 *problem this creates* 就是：**同一套理论（脑大=语言强）被两类证据打脸**——化石证据与考古证据推向相反结论，说明假设有问题。**排除 B：**不是 “化石证据不足”，相反文中有化石证据；问题在于 “证据冲突＋假设错误”。**排除 C：**C 把对象说反了（文中是 Neanderthals brains larger）。**排除 D：**D 与原文相反（原文说 Neanderthals lacked capacity for language）。 |
| 29 | A | 作者如何评价 1781 年 Jean-Jacques Rousseau 的著作？ | **第 4 段**：“*…Rousseau’s On the Origin of Language was a reflection on both music and language… Those authors have an important lesson to learn from Rousseau…*” | “卢梭的《论语言起源》同时反思音乐与语言……这些作者应当从卢梭及同时代作家那里学到重要一课。” | **选 A：**作者明确说后人（尤其忽略音乐的那些学者）**要向卢梭学习**，等同于 “现代理论家应该更多关注他的思路”。**排除 B：**第 4 段说 “那些惹恼该协会的人很清楚音乐与语言相连”，卢梭属于 “把音乐与语言联系起来” 的一派，不是 “支持协会”。**排除 C：作者是把卢梭与后来的《Language Evolution》对比：后者没提音乐**，不是 “继承/镜像卢梭”。**排除 D：**作者态度相反：认为卢梭仍有启发（lesson to learn），不认为过时。 |
| 30 | D | 作者目前如何看待 Derek Bickerton 的观点？ | **第 7 段**：“*But Bickerton’s idea … is, I believe, fundamentally mistaken.*” | “但我认为，比克顿的观点从根本上就是错误的。” | **选 D：**题干问 “current view”，作者直接下结论 **fundamentally mistaken**（根本性错误），对应 “其背后的假设是错的”。**排除 A：**文中说该观点 “dominated the field… for the last two decades”（主导该领域二十年），影响巨大，绝非 “影响很小”。**排除 B：**作者说它 “severely limited the progress”（严重限制进展），不是 “推动进步”。**排除 C：**作者没说 “多数语言学家不接受”，反而说它长期主导；问题是作者认为它错，不是 “接受度低”。 |
| 31 | C | 最后一段作者认为 Alison Wray 的观点将帮助建立什么之间的联系？ | **第 8 段末**：“*…understand the origin of music as well as language, and to relate both to the emotional lives of our human ancestors.*” | “……使我们能理解音乐与语言的起源，并把二者都与人类祖先的情感生活联系起来。” | **选 C：**“原句把三者直接连起来：**language + music + emotions**。**排除 A：**A 是 “语法与意义”，不符合末句主旨；语法只在前面解释 “rule system (grammar)” 作背景。**排除 B：**B “messages 与 proto-language” 是作者对 Wray 理论的内部定义，不是 “最终要建立的 link”。**排除 D：**D “proto-language 与 modern semantics” 不对，文中说 proto-language “semantically complex”，但最终落点是音乐＋语言＋情感。 |

## 题型二：句子配对 32–37（人名/机构 → 对应描述 A–H）

> 题干翻译：为每个句子（32–37）选择正确结尾（A–H），把对应字母写在答题卡上。

| 题号 | 答案 | 题干翻译 | 详细定位（第X段 原句） | 定位句翻译 | 详细解析（为什么是它） |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 32 | D | Société de Linguistique de Paris（巴黎语言学会）…… | **第1段**：*"…in 1866 the influential Société de Linguistique de Paris banned all discussions about the origin of language."* | "1866年……巴黎语言学会禁止一切关于语言起源的讨论。" | "banned all discussions" = **认为不该讨论/禁止辩论** → 对应 **D**（felt that the origin of language should not be debated）。 |
| 33 | H | Charles Darwin…… | **第3段**：*"…Darwin who, in his 1871 book on human evolution, The Descent of Man, devoted several pages to the development of music."* | "达尔文在1871年关于人类进化的著作《人类的由来》中，用数页讨论音乐的发展。" | 关键词：*book on human evolution* + *devoted…to music* → **H**（referred to music in part of a book about the development of human beings）。 |
| 34 | A | John Blacking…… | **第3段**：*"…Blacking… broached the idea that music is an inherent and universal human quality."* | "布莱金提出：音乐是人类与生俱来且普遍存在的品质。" | "inherent and universal… human quality" ≈ 音乐对每个人都很关键/普遍必备 → 最贴近 **A**（suggested music was an essential part of every individual）。 |
| 35 | B | Morten Christiansen 和 Simon Kirby…… | **第4段**：*"…their book, Language Evolution … failed to mention music in any of its 17 chapters."* | "他们的《语言进化》……17章里完全没提音乐。" | "definitive book" 但 "failed to mention music" = 在综合研究里**没把音乐与语言联系起来** → **B**。 |
| 36 | E | （Derek Bickerton）…… | **第7段**：*"…precursor… consisted of words strung together with limited, if any, grammar… 'proto-language' … similar to … young children…"* | "语言的前身是把词串在一起，几乎没有语法……类似小孩语言。" | 这就是 "基本词汇 + 不系统的使用（缺乏语法规则）" → **E**（early language was made up of basic words used in an unsystematic way）。 |
| 37 | G | （Alison Wray）…… | **第8段**：*"…proto-language was… composed of 'messages' rather than words… they were not composed out of smaller units of meaning (i.e. words)…"* | "原始语言由 '信息包/整体信息' 构成，而非词；它们不是由更小的意义单位（词）组合而成。" | 明确说 proto-language **没有由单个词构成**（不是词的组合）→ **G**（proto-language had no individual words）。 |

---

## 题型三：多选题 38–40（选 THREE letters）

> 题干翻译：根据作者观点，为理解语言起源，下列哪些三个领域研究不足？（选3个）

| 题号 | 答案 | 题干翻译 | 详细定位（第X段 原句） | 定位句翻译 | 详细解析 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 38–40 | A, D, E | 根据作者，下列哪些领域研究不够，从而无法理解语言起源？（选三项） | **第2段**：*"insufficient concern with the archaeological and fossil proof…"*；**第3段**：*"insufficient concern…: music."*；**第6段**：*"an insufficient concern with emotion."* | "对考古与化石证据关注不足"；"对音乐关注不足"；"对情感关注不足"。 | 三个 "研究不足" 的点是作者列的四大原因里的前三个：**A evidence from prehistoric times** 对应 "archaeological and fossil proof"（考古/化石=史前证据）。**D music** 直接点名 "music"。**E emotions** 直接点名 "emotion"。其余选项（intelligence / individual sounds / human intellect / children's language）在这段材料里**不是作者明确列为 'insufficient concern' 的三项**。 |